Instructor Guide: Peer Feedback Round

Type: Small-group discussion (pairs or groups of 3) **Time:** 10 minutes (2 min note-taking during the peer briefing + 3 min written feedback + 2 min exchange + 3 min group synthesis)

Pre-Activity Setup

- Print or distribute the peer feedback form before the capstone delivery round starts. Every learner needs one form per peer they will give feedback to. If groups are three, each learner writes two forms and receives two in return; if groups are four, three and three. Hand the forms out before the briefings start — learners need them in hand while watching, not after.
- Have the four-dimension rubric visible on the wall during this activity as well, not just during the capstone build. The feedback is rubric-tied; the rubric needs to be where learners can glance at it.
- Prepare a single reference example on the whiteboard: one strong observation per rubric dimension, tied to a specific slide or moment in a reference briefing you delivered or showed in demo. This is the bar the class is writing to.
- If your room supports it, arrange pairs so that the executive-version and technical-version learners exchange feedback (not same-version to same-version). The contrast helps both sides — technical-version learners see what a recommendation-first briefing actually looks like, and executive-version learners see what a full methodology walk-through reveals about their own cuts.

Facilitation Steps

1. **Pre-activity during capstone delivery** (overlaps with delivery window): Remind learners to take written notes against the rubric during each peer's briefing. You will see some learners forget and just listen — stop them mid-briefing and push them to write. Specifics come from notes, not memory.

2. **0:00 — Launch** (1 min): Project the whiteboard reference example. Name the contrast between a strong observation ("slide 3's sentence title named the finding — I knew the takeaway before you narrated it") and a weak one ("your intro was

good"). The first is actionable; the second is not. The rest of this activity is about staying in the first category.

3. **0:01 — Written feedback** (3 min): Silent writing. Circulate. Watch for learners staring at the form — they are in the "I cannot think of anything specific" state, which almost always means they did not take notes during the briefing. Prompt them gently: "What happened on slide 3? What did you actually see?" The specifics come back when you force them to recall the slide number.
4. **0:04 — Exchange in pairs** (4 min, 2 min each direction): The listener thanks the giver and does not argue the feedback; the giver reads the form aloud. Interrupt any pair where the listener is defending ("but the reason I did that was..."). Redirect: "You can disagree silently and write a better briefing next time. For now, just receive."
5. **0:08 — Group synthesis** (2 min): Go around the group (or the room, if time permits). Each learner names one specific change they will make to their next briefing. Capture patterns on the whiteboard. Common patterns: "cut an earlier slide," "annotate every chart, not just the trend chart," "write the recommendation sentence before opening PowerPoint."
6. **Close — Submit forms**: Collect the written forms. They are data points for the course-completion assessment and worth reviewing later to calibrate your own facilitation for the next cohort.

What to Circulate For

- **Generic feedback.** "Your deck was nice" is useless. "Slide 4 lost me because I could not tell which severity was Medium on the donut" is gold. If you see a form filled with genericisms, quietly return it with "pick one specific moment and write what you actually saw on the projector."
- **Feedback that is personal rather than rubric-tied.** "I would have worn a different color" is about personal preference, not the rubric. Redirect: "Was that a data handling, visualization, presentation, or communication issue? If it is not one of the four, it does not belong on this form."
- **Listeners who argue the feedback.** This is the most common facilitation intervention. Interrupt politely: "You can think the feedback is wrong. Right now,

your job is to receive, not to defend. Write down whatever you want to push back on later — but not now."

- **Learners who only write positive feedback.** Balance matters. The form asks for two things that worked AND one thing to change. If a form has three things that worked and nothing to change, push: "Nothing to change? Nothing at all? Pick the weakest moment in the briefing — there was one — and name it."
- **Follow-up questions that are not real questions.** "I would have asked what they meant" is not a question. A real follow-up question is: "I would have asked 'what is the cost delta if you refactor one runbook instead of three?'" Specific, grounded in the briefing content.

Common Pitfalls

- **"I do not want to be mean."** The most common block to specific feedback. Reframe: "Specific feedback is the opposite of mean. Vague feedback leaves the receiver unsure what to change; specific feedback is a gift because it is actionable." Use the giver's own experience — "when have you received feedback that was useful? Was it vague or specific?"
- **The form takes longer than 3 minutes.** Watch the clock. If learners are not done at 3 minutes, give a 30-second warning, then stop. The exchange is the teaching moment, not the writing. An incomplete form exchanged is more valuable than a complete form not exchanged.
- **Pairs synthesize instead of exchange.** Some pairs will skip reading the form aloud and just summarize verbally. Intervene: "Read what you wrote. The words on the form are what got committed — the summary drifts." Force the handover to be literal.
- **Group synthesis becomes monologue.** If one learner takes up the whole synthesis window with a detailed story of their own briefing, cut them off kindly: "One sentence: what will you change next time?"
- **Form submission gets forgotten.** End the activity explicitly with "hand your forms to me on your way to the wrap-up." Lost forms are lost data.

Debrief Prompts

- **"What specific feedback did you receive that surprised you?"** Draws out the moments when the receiver genuinely saw their own briefing from a different angle. Those are the highest-leverage moments — the receiver is about to change behavior, not just nod.
- **"What was hardest — giving or receiving?"** Almost everyone says receiving. Use the moment to name the skill: "Receiving feedback without defending is something most people never get better at. Five minutes of practice here compounds over years at work."
- **"If you had to give yourself feedback on your own briefing, what would it say?"** Close with this. The learner who can self-critique accurately has made the course skill their own. The learner who cannot has learned the checklist but not the judgment. Use the pattern you hear to calibrate whether a one-on-one follow-up is warranted.

Expected Answers

A reference-quality peer feedback form has these characteristics:

Element	Expected value
Dimension coverage	At least one observation in each of the four rubric rows (data handling, visualization, presentation, communication).
Specificity	Every observation cites a slide number, a chart element, a specific sentence, or a specific moment. No generic "intro was good" language.
Balance	Two things that worked; one thing to change. Not zero things to change (unbalanced praise) and not zero things that worked (unbalanced critique).
Follow-up question	One real question the giver would have asked if they had been in a real audience, plus a one-line note on how the presenter could have been prepared (appendix slide, anticipated-question list, prepared caveat).
Rubric-tied	Every observation maps to one of the four rubric dimensions. Observations about personal style, voice, or dress do not appear on the form.
Listener receipt	The listener thanked the giver, asked at most one clarifying question, and did not argue. This is observed, not written.

If a form is missing an element but the exchange was clearly useful (the learner names a specific change in the group synthesis), accept the form and note the gap for next cohort's facilitation calibration. The goal is the exchange, not the paperwork.